LAN Talk: Simple Two-User Chat Application

1. Introduction

LAN Talk is a simple chat application that allows two users on two laptops connected to the same Wi-Fi network to send messages to each other. It is written in PHP with basic HTML and CSS, and runs on the Apache server provided by XAMPP. Messages are stored in a text file named messages.txt. No JavaScript, database, JSON, AJAX, WebSockets, frameworks or external libraries are used.

2. Files Used

- **index.php** – Asks for the user's name and stores it in a PHP session.
- **chat.php** – Saves new messages to messages.txt and displays all messages.
- **logout.php** – Ends the session and returns to the first page.
- **messages.txt** – Stores all messages, one message per line.
- **style.css** – Contains the styling for the pages.

3. Working

The user enters a name on the first page, which is saved in a session. On the chat page, the user types a message and presses Send. The message is sent to PHP using an HTML POST form, and PHP adds the name and message to the end of messages.txt. The chat page reads the file and shows every message. Users press Refresh to see new messages. All names and messages are displayed using htmlspecialchars() for safety.

4. Running the Application

1. Place the project folder in C:\xampp\htdocs\chat-app.
2. Open the XAMPP Control Panel and start Apache.
3. On the server laptop, open http://localhost/chat-app/ in a browser.

5. Accessing from the Second Laptop

1. On the server laptop, run the ipconfig command and note the IPv4 Address (for example, 192.168.1.5).
2. Connect the second laptop to the same Wi-Fi network.
3. On the second laptop, open http://192.168.1.5/chat-app/ in a browser.

If the page does not open, allow Apache through the Windows Firewall on the server laptop.

6. Sharing Messages

Only the server laptop runs PHP, so there is only one messages.txt file. Messages from both laptops are saved in this same file, and both laptops read from it. This is how both users see the same conversation.

7. Conclusion

LAN Talk shows how a basic chat application can be built using only PHP forms, sessions and a text file, and shared between two laptops over a local Wi-Fi network.